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WOMEN E-SPORT ATHLETES COMPETE IN INDIA, A WHOPPING 40 PER CENT OF THE COUNTRY'S TOTAL GAMING POPULATION

Source: Niko Partners' India Gamer Behavior and Market Insights

ATUL KUMAR YADAV



Tarushika, 24
E-sports athlete and content creator from Sonepat

Gaming avatar: Sheek

Play time: 4-5 hours a day

"There are a lot of trolls who have a lot to say about us. They have a certain beauty standard they want to fit a girl gamer into. I have been ignoring most of that"

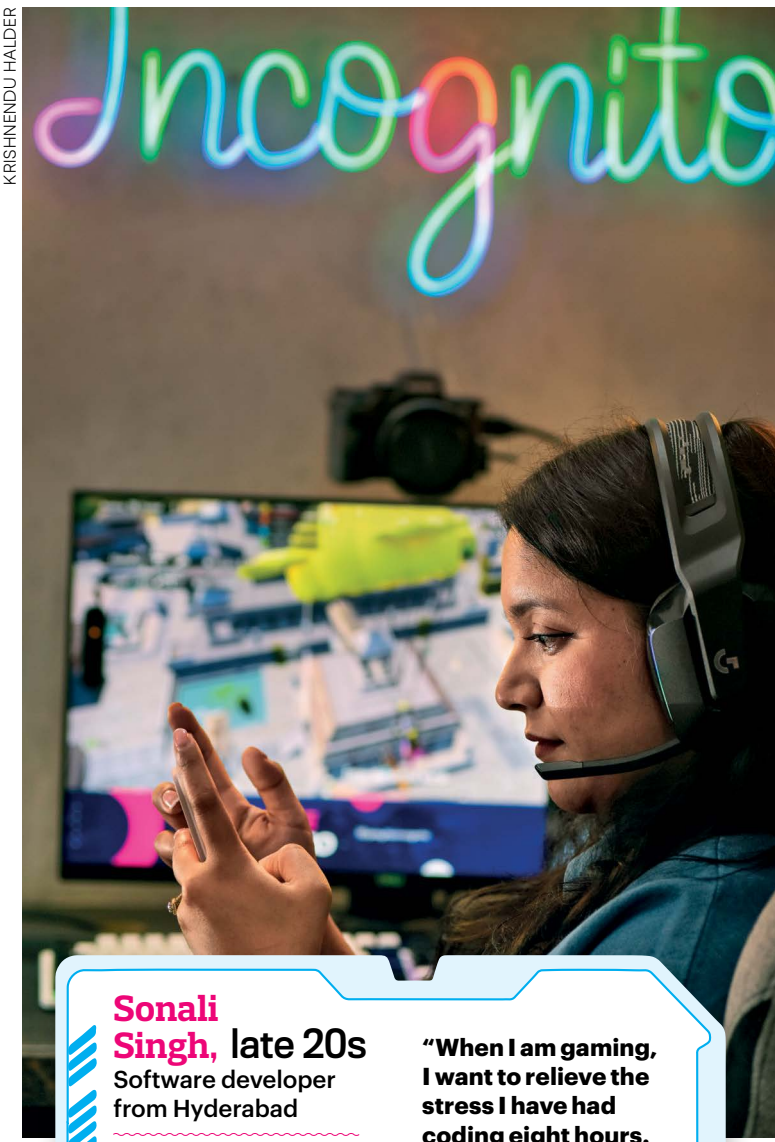
stating that the female fanbase in e-sports is rising, "fuelled by Bollywood collaborations and more female characters in games". Aficionados such as Payal Dhare, 25—with a 4.6 million-plus subscriber count on YouTube—livestream their skills on the arenas of Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI), Grand Theft Auto V, Fall Guys and Call of Duty. Pros like Tarushika (a.k.a. Sheek), 24, who was part of the team that recently won the BGMI Series 2025, one of India's biggest tournaments, are popularising the movement nationally.

Most female gamers, like Saloni, trace their interest to brothers. Payal recalls watching her cousins play back in Umranala in Chhindwara district, Madhya Pradesh, and begging for a turn. Mumbai-based Kaashvi Hiranandani (a.k.a. KaashPlays), 28, started as young as four with Atari and Nintendo, thanks to her elder brother who wanted her to play with him. "If he was playing a multiplayer game, I got the Player 2 remote," she says.

Slaying the Patriarchy

But old taboos die hard. Even when young girls got a chance in the ring, they would have to combat prejudices in the form of "Oh, wow, you're into gaming?" or "Hey, you're better than other girls!". It's only as they grew up, recalls Kaashvi, that the "competitive spirit" of wanting to outdo each other superseded any inhibitions around naysayers. This hobby had its fair share of those in the family. Saloni remembers well how in her early days of gaming, her mother would barge into her room and turn off her livestreams with admonitions. Today, her parents encourage her to compete in cash tournaments but, back then, "it used to be a whole drama", she laughs. Sonali Singh, a Hyderabad-based software developer in her late twenties,

KRISHNENDU HALDER



Sonali Singh, late 20s
Software developer from Hyderabad

Gaming avatar: Play Like Incognito

Play time: 2-3 hours a day

"When I am gaming, I want to relieve the stress I have had coding eight hours. I don't socialise much, so gaming helps me connect with my friends"